

Chapter 31 - Meeting

This rose bush was very beautiful, delicate and captivating. The red color at the edges of the petals looked like someone had accidentally dripped blood on them, and it was precisely this touch of red that gave it a somewhat decadent, battle-worn beauty.

Fu Sixue looked at the rose bush with slightly raised eyebrows and a smile curving at the corner of her mouth. It seemed Ah Lin was finally getting some sense, learning to cater to preferences.

"What a beautiful rose bush." Feng Yue's expression remained normal, looking quite pleased, "Shuangshuang, where did you buy this rose bush?"

Dai Shuangshuang had only received the task from her sister to deliver things upstairs, and she didn't even know what was inside the boxes before Feng Yue opened them.

Now asking her where she bought the roses - how could she possibly know?

Dai Shuangshuang hemmed and hawed, deflecting, "Haha, I just asked a friend to buy it for you. I'm not sure exactly where it was bought."

Fu Sixue's gaze paused, then she instinctively looked toward Feng Yue, who didn't seem to have any strange reaction after hearing Dai Shuangshuang's words.

She probably... didn't figure it out.

Feng Yue just smiled with what seemed like slight regret, "Alright. But thank you anyway."

Dai Shuangshuang breathed a sigh of relief, "No problem, take a look at the other one too." She quickly changed the subject.

Feng Yue nodded and began unpacking the other box. The gift inside this box was much more normal - it was a coffee machine, and judging by the brand, it wouldn't be cheap.

Feng Yue used to love drinking coffee in the morning, but due to her condition, she hadn't had any for quite some time. So when Zhou Qiongqiong wanted coffee in the morning, there were only a few packets of instant coffee at home.

"A coffee machine! That's great, my house was just missing one." Feng Yue picked up the coffee machine and headed straight into the kitchen, while the rose bush that Feng Yue had said she liked was left alone where it was.

Dai Shuangshuang exchanged a subtle glance with Fu Sixue, then quickly looked away. They both understood what the other meant.

Moon/Sister Yueyue probably knew the real source of this rose bush.

The two sighed almost imperceptibly, then followed Feng Yue's footsteps into the kitchen. The rose bush remained alone where it was.

Yan Lin sat in the car with all the windows rolled down. The ashtray inside was already filled with cigarette butts, and she held the last cigarette between her fingers.

Yan Lin rarely smoked, and even when she did, she mostly just lit them and held them between her fingers.

She didn't like the taste of nicotine filling her mouth, but she enjoyed watching the sparks slowly consume the tobacco. This helped her calm down quickly and focus her thoughts.

But at this moment, even after lighting countless cigarettes, she could hardly think of a solution.

She didn't know what to do about Feng Yue.

Just as Fu Sixue had said, Feng Yue was an excellent woman - beautiful, gentle, and intelligent. More suitors would gather around her.

Wenzhen might just be one of them.

Yan Lin knew in her heart that Feng Yue wouldn't easily accept another person, but even knowing this, she still felt uncertain.

Between her and Feng Yue, she was always the passive one.

And now Feng Yue had already excluded her from her world.

Yan Lin didn't know whether Feng Yue would notice the true origin of that rose bush. Her heart was still conflicted.

On one hand, she hoped Feng Yue would know the rose bush was from her; on the other hand, she hoped Feng Yue wouldn't discover it.

While Yan Lin was deep in thought, her phone beside her chimed with a message from Fu Sixue.

Fu Sixue: [Moon probably knows.]

This short sentence finally let Yan Lin's heart, which had been stuck in her throat, settle. For a moment, she didn't know whether she felt happy or disappointed.

She didn't reply to Fu Sixue's message, just put her phone back in place and emptied her thoughts.

She needed to think carefully, to consider properly.

Fu Sixue put away her phone and watched as Feng Yue came out of the kitchen and directly moved the rose bush to the balcony without saying a word.

After returning from the balcony to the living room, Feng Yue resumed her previous demeanor, still joking and chatting with everyone as if the rose bush had never appeared.

After Dai Shuangshuang arrived, everyone for today was finally here. Before five o'clock, they began preparing ingredients for dinner - their evening meal would be long-awaited hot pot¹.

The kitchen was Feng Yue and Wenzhen's domain, while the others arranged chairs in the dining room and neatly displayed the ingredients Wenzhen had prepared.

The hot pot base was something Feng Yue had learned from her mother. Their family's ancestors were from the Sichuan-Chongqing region, so they naturally had their own method for preparing hot pot base.

However, considering everyone's relatively mild taste preferences, the hot pot base she prepared tonight wasn't very spicy, just very aromatic.

Only after everything was ready did Feng Yue emerge from the kitchen carrying a pot of freshly made hot pot base.

The early autumn evenings were getting cooler, so when everyone saw this steaming pot of hot pot, they all felt warmed up.

"Wow, so fragrant!" This was Zhou Qiongqiong, who had been dieting for a while.

"It smells even better than what I've had at hot pot restaurants!" This was Dai Shuangshuang, who hadn't seen much of the world.

"Quick, put some meat in! I'm so hungry, so hungry, so hungry!" This was Fu Sixue, a starving ghost reincarnated².

"Do you want to eat some of my vegetables? I'll cook some for you." This was Wenzhen, sitting beside Feng Yue.

Regarding Wenzhen's care that was almost like looking after a small child, Feng Yue sometimes felt a bit overwhelmed, "It's okay, it's okay, I can reach them myself."

Wenzhen naturally understood the principle of moderation. When she noticed Feng Yue was a bit uncomfortable, she would immediately stop her excessive actions and advances.

Fu Sixue, sitting across from them, took in everything with her eyes. She lowered her gaze, a flash of inscrutable light passing through her eyes.

Zhou Qiongqiong didn't sense any atmosphere at all - she was just someone who had been dieting for days and wanted to eat, "Senior sister, I want some of those goose intestines³ from your side. Could you cook some for me?"

"Get them yourself." Wenzhen passed the plate of goose intestines to her.

Zhou Qiongqiong was completely stunned by her senior sister's blatant double standard, but looking at Feng Yue and then at her senior sister, she opened her mouth but said nothing.

Since Wenzhen still needed to drive that evening, she didn't drink alcohol like Feng Yue, and instead drank Feng Yue's homemade fruit tea.

The other three, without Wenzhen's control, managed to drink more than half of the bottle of Romanée-Conti that Fu Sixue had brought.

They ate hot pot for a long time, and by the time they were almost finished, the wine's aftereffects were starting to kick in.

They had drunk more tonight than at lunch, so naturally they were more intoxicated.

Feng Yue looked at Zhou Qiongqiong and Dai Shuangshuang, who were practically melting into the sofa, with a bit of a headache.

Wenzhen, meanwhile, was being stared at by Fu Sixue, who sat quietly to the side with a stern face and not saying a word, making her feel quite unsettled.

Seeing this, Feng Yue quickly went over to block Fu Sixue's view, bending down to ask, "Xiaoxue, are you drunk?"

Fu Sixue's gaze slowly fell on her, then after thinking for a moment, she shook her head and said clearly, "No, I'm very clear-headed."

Feng Yue had rarely seen Fu Sixue after drinking, and she didn't know whether her current state counted as being drunk.

The last time she came to drink at her house, when she had too much she immediately became dizzy and went to bed to sleep. Her current state seemed completely different from last time.

Although her reactions were a bit slow, her speech was very clear - the kind of state where if you didn't look at her face, you couldn't tell she'd been drinking at all.

Dai Shuangshuang would have her family's driver pick her up later, and Zhou Qiongqiong could be driven home by Wenzhen, so what should they do with this little ancestor?

"Would you like to sleep at my place tonight? The guest room is very clean, you don't have to squeeze in with me." Feng Yue asked with some worry.

Fu Sixue looked a bit dazed, as if her brain was working hard to process and analyze what Feng Yue had said. After a while, she said, "No need, a friend is coming downstairs to pick me up."

With that, Feng Yue watched as Fu Sixue took out her phone and sent a message to someone, then looked up at her.

"Done." Fu Sixue stood up directly. Although she was a bit unsteady, she could still manage to walk forward.

Feng Yue naturally wasn't comfortable letting her go downstairs alone. After giving Wenzhen some instructions, she helped Fu Sixue out the door.

The two stood quietly in the elevator, with Feng Yue carrying Fu Sixue's bag for her.

As soon as the elevator doors opened, a cold wind blew toward them. Fu Sixue had left in a hurry, and Feng Yue, watching after her, hadn't even had time to put on a coat. She was now wearing only a simple short-sleeved t-shirt.

The sudden gust of cold wind made her shiver. But she didn't pay much attention to it, just helped Fu Sixue, this drunk person, walk toward the outside of the residential complex.

When Yan Lin received Fu Sixue's message, she opened the car door and got out - partly to disperse the smoke smell that had accumulated in the car, and partly to get some fresh air to clear her head.

So when her gaze met Feng Yue's, she was momentarily stunned.

The next second, she quickly looked away and turned around, frantically looking for a place to hide.

Damn it, how could Fu Sixue come downstairs with Ayue?

She had always kept in mind that she shouldn't appear in front of Feng Yue, shouldn't ruin Feng Yue's good mood.

"Are you here to pick her up?" Feng Yue's voice was flat, revealing no emotion.

Yan Lin stopped in her tracks, then turned around and nodded, then remembered something and quickly said, "Sorry, I didn't mean to appear—"

Feng Yue didn't wait for her to finish and interrupted, "Fine, I'll leave her to you." She directly opened the passenger door and stuffed the dazed Fu Sixue inside.

Feng Yue carefully settled Fu Sixue in the passenger seat, then put her bag in the car and slammed the door shut with a "bang."

Feng Yue did all this smoothly, then with a cold face, slightly nodded to Yan Lin and turned to leave.

Yan Lin stood there in a daze, watching Feng Yue do all this. When she saw Feng Yue's retreating figure, she opened her mouth but ultimately said nothing.

This encounter, which could almost be called hurried, made the longing for Feng Yue that Yan Lin had been suppressing surge wildly.

She wanted to grab the corner of the other person's departing clothes, she wanted to gently embrace her, she wanted to whisper her longing in her ear.

But these remained only thoughts.

Author's Note:

How can everyone have illusions about little Fu? She came back to the country early because of Yan Lin's email! In her eyes, Yan Lin is a childhood friend she grew up with, while Yueyue is a friend she met in middle school. Moreover, little Fu went abroad in high school, when Yueyue and Yan Lin were in their youth with their cat-and-mouse chase and warming feelings. She completely missed that whole period. Even though she heard Yan Lin personally mention those excessive things, she never witnessed them firsthand - she doesn't have a God's perspective. But she does consider Yueyue a friend, it's just that she unconsciously considers things from Yan Lin's perspective. As for whether she's watching the drama unfold, she is indeed watching - but she's watching Yan Lin's drama. However, if she can secretly help Yan Lin, she still would.

Footnotes:

1. **Hot pot (火锅)** - A Chinese cooking method where raw ingredients are cooked in a simmering pot of seasoned broth at the dining table. Very popular for social gatherings.
2. **Starving ghost reincarnated (饿死鬼投胎)** - A humorous Chinese expression describing someone who is always extremely hungry or eager to eat, as if they were a hungry ghost from their previous life.
3. **Goose intestines (鹅肠)** - A popular hot pot ingredient in Chinese cuisine, prized for its crispy texture when briefly cooked.